

Democracy at Gunpoint

HAMEEDA HOSSAIN

EVEN as counting began for the national elections to Bangladesh' Parliament, it was obvious that the promise of democracy held out during four years of military rule had turned sour. As Lord Ennals summed up the elections in his report to the Gononirbachon Commission: "a historical moment for democracy had turned into a tragedy for democracy". Not only because of the use of organised violence, or by direct manipulation of the administration and its Election Commission but by the total denial of the electorate. In the words of a candidate: "to win it is not necessary to canvas voters, only to assure votes".

When he assumed office at gunpoint at midnight of March 24, 1982, General Hussain Mohammad Ershad, Chief Martial Law Administrator (CMLA) and self-declared President of the People's Republic of Bangladesh expressed his ambition to restore democracy through the electoral process. At the same time, he articulated the expectations of his military constituency: their divine right to rule, to exploit national resources and to appropriate aid surpluses. A fundamental contradiction between the two objectives has kept Bangladesh in the grip of Martial Law for four years; it has denied General Ershad the legitimacy he so desperately seeks; it has edged the country to an unstable stalemate.

Traditional military rulers in the sub-continent have presumed that it is their prerogative to guide democracy and it is for the people to bend in gratitude. Gen Ershad has tried to follow the manual which prescribes that a *coup d'etat* has, in course of time, to be constitutionally validated. Unfortunately the major political parties have been unwilling to legitimise his rule, and the people of Bangladesh have, whenever occasion demanded, tried to obstruct the institutionalising of military rule.

In March 1985, Gen Ershad banned political activity and blitzkrieged through a referendum which he claimed gave him a 95 per cent majority in a 75 per cent poll. But the rest of the country knew that there was no more than a 5 per cent turn-out. He was then induced to hold a non-party Upazilla elections for local government in May 1985. Given the dependence of the Upazillas on resources from the Centre, he expected to bypass mainstream Opposition and buy a support base amongst the rural elite. In spite of the former's impotence to frustrate the elections, their rural support has not whittled, and their strategy did not permit Gen Ershad to don *mufti*.

Other changes initiated by him have brought in few returns and only contributed to aggravating the problems. Decentralisation of the judiciary and

administration indiscriminate privatisation of industries have alienated significant portions of the professional groups particularly the lawyers, doctors, students and workers. The business community, traditionally a major supporter of military regimes may have contributed to Gen Ershad's 'relief fund for election campaign' but it has expressed little confidence in his administrative and financial management.

In November 1986, faced by the end of his term of office as Chief of Staff, Gen Ershad decided to stake his survival through a parliamentary election. Having drawn upon the pickings of a political dust-bin-men such as Anwar Zahid or Kazi Zafar who had lost their security deposits in earlier elections, Maudood Ahmed, who may have set a record for changing political affiliations but always remaining in the official party, other smaller fry coopted from the BNP and mercenary toughs, he sponsored the Jatiyo Party (JP).

On, March 21 General announced the target date of May 7 for parliamentary elections. But there were doubts that this would lead to a transfer of power from military rule to the elected representatives of the people. Although he conceded some of the Opposition demands for neutrality of the administration and resignation of sitting Ministers, it became fairly obvious within three days of his announcement that he would play foul with his own promise to the nation to keep himself in power.

The election announcement itself created both apprehension and expectation. The BNP and its junior partners threatened a boycott on the grounds that conditions for a free and fair election enunciated through the five-point demand of the 22 parties did not prevail. Underlying their reaction was an awareness of their electoral weakness in view of the fact that their senior leaders were disqualified as a result of convictions and many of their ex-MP's had gone over to Jatiyo Party.

The fifteen parties led by the Awami League (AL) committed themselves to elections, despite Ershad's provocations on the calculation that if he remained serious about his neutrality offer they would be able to galvanise grass-root support for their candidates; if he did not keep his word they would still use the election for mobilisation. Four minor parties in this alliance opted for a boycott probably because their numerical insignificance would make them invisible. The CPB, Jamaat and NAP stayed in because any exposure gained through participation with the mainstream would be to their advantage.

Elections were held in uncertainty. The results,

having been formulated through administrative manipulation and use of gunpower have created even greater uncertainty. If Gen Ershad expected to carry the Jatiyo Party on his shoulders, intelligence reports must have advised him to be in battle-dress for May 7. Two days earlier warrants were issued against party workers in many constituencies to inactivate opposition defences. In the systematic and entirely organised assault on voters which ensued on May 7, the capital city wore a beleaguered look: Terror, threats and violence rode the day, even as mercenaries recruited by JP candidates surfaced. Gangs of 20 or 30 strong, waving rods, stens, *ramdas* turned fast corners in newly appropriated jeeps, broke election camps; knives in hand they hijacked boxes; obstructed polling booths; hit presiding women officers. Bangladesh Rifles (BDR) personnel and police officers who seemed to have been instructed to keep a low profile when ordinary voters or presiding officers appealed for help, turned to immediate support of a jeep loaded with sten guns commandeered by a JP candidate, surrounded by an outraged crowd. In another constituency, Dr Feroza Begum, an Awami League candidate, was shown in the lead. At 12.30 p.m. her prospective son-in-law was stabbed in his legs

and lay gravely wounded, as Jatiyo Party thugs proceeded to reverse the voting trend. These tactics ensured an improbable victory for the Jatiyo Party in Dhaka; results filtering in from the Election Commission at 5 p.m. on May 8 indicated that voting had been suspended in many centres in Demra due to violence. But five hours later a news bulletin, edited reportedly by the CMLA's office, gave the seat to a JP candidate.

The story was no different elsewhere. Voting was reported to be uniformly low. Yet Jatiyo Party ex-Ministers who had resigned on March 21, won astounding leads of well over one lakh votes. Considering that none of them were particularly charismatic, that some of them had lost their deposits in earlier elections and that polling in their constituencies defined the national average, this could only be rationalised by the need to reappoint them as Ministers. Although much of the gangsterism was left to hired hoodlums invested with total immunity, as all laws seemed to have been suspended on the voting day, the Government strategy was to deploy its strength in the cities, to ensure victory for its ex-Ministers and to defeat the leaders and effective members of Parliamentary Opposition. Where candidates had built strong defences and JP mercenaries could not occupy booths, BDR and the Army were summoned as reinforcements particularly outside the cities. In Bogra, the result declared in favour of an AL candidate was allegedly reversed in favour of the JP candidate at the orders of an Army Colonel. A normal operation was to cordon off an area, clear all voters and stuff the boxes.

Where Opposition parties have won, several reasons can be ascribed:

- (1) where the Government abstained from abettment, the JP was unable to use force effectively and voting favoured the Opposition candidate;
- (2) the rival candidate was able to muster enough muscle to counter their force;
- (3) a preemptive use of force by some Opposition candidates sustained their victory;
- (4) some Independent candidates had to be permitted in Parliament particularly if they could be pressured to contribute to the two-thirds majority of the Government.

The widespread outrage inspired by such organised barbarism has obviously left the rulers untouched. For they have been busy in their manipulations to obtain a two-thirds majority in a house of 330. Between May 11 and 19, polling was rescheduled in several centres where it had been officially suspended. The reason was the spate of violence, but announced results suggests that this has helped to stretch the JP seats to 155. With 30 women to be elected by the majority members in the house, the JP will require another 38. They will have to make tempting offers to the JSD (5 seats) Muslim League (4 seats) and Independents (33 seats), to ensure a margin of security for Ershad to call the Parliament which would indemnify all martial law acts and approve his presidency. To

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COMMUNICATION

Indian-English

Mainstream (May 10, 1986) reproduced from Seminar an article on Indian-English captioned "Coming Home", by H.Y. Sharada Prasad, Information Adviser to the Prime Minister. In response to it, he received the following letter which he has passed on to **Mainstream**:

Dear Sir M.R. Ry Sharada Pd. Avl.,

I am hopeless after perusing your assaultage on us people who are practicing the noble English languagification, both spoken, written, prosed and poetised as the case may be with due process.

Sir, you are is a exalted eminence of suitable gravity sitting on a pinnacle nextmost to our respective beloved Prime Minister Thiru Rajive Gahdhi and spouse Thirumati Sonia Gandhi in holy blessed wedlock. Humbly yov are is obligationed in such dire circumstances to deportmentalise yourself in humble postures, as I may it appears arrongantly but actually handfolded suggest.

It is, therefore, misbeseeming or your pristine self to hurl ruthlessnessly oppressive thunderbolts of criticalisms against our sustained retrograde English usification. Sir, we are not Shakespearewallahs, Miltonists or Wordsworthisers also etc. So indeed not ever gentle Lambites, Hoodlums or Baconers. We have had is nicely and simply irrigated in Nesfields like anything and grammatised to act accordingly with retrospective effect and preponement. Therefore and accordingly as per rules, please treat us people according to our lights all in all without malices towards none at all and purple compassions to everyone unto this lasts. Thank you so much in advance.

Yours faithfully
Somarayan

Mainstream

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EDITOR'S NOTEBOOK

Patchwork

BHAJAN LAL's sudden resignation from Chief Ministership of Haryana on June 4 looks like a melodrama; but for a New Delhi observer it was neither totally unexpected nor is it inexplicable.

At the formal level, it would appear that Bhajan Lal having almost staked his political career to get Abohar and Fazilka for Haryana, was left with no option but to quit when the Prime Minister announced the unconditional transfer of Chandigarh on June 21 while he found no way to browbeat the Venkataramiah Commission to give Abohar and Fazilka to Haryana. Actually, it was known for sometime that Bhajan Lal's removal was on the cards, as a good section of the Congress-I MLAs had made it amply clear to the party President that his continuation as Chief Minister would destroy all chances of a Congress-I victory at the next Assembly poll.

Bansi Lal's reversion to Haryana as its new Chief Minister was also not unexpected as it was given out at the time of his resurrection as a Central Cabinet Minister that this meant as a *Kayakalpa* in preparation for his return to Haryana.

The immediate compulsion behind this change of guards is of course the Centre's anxiety to control the situation in Haryana following the award of the Venkataramiah Commission and the ceremonial transfer of Chandigarh to Punjab on June 21, both of which might touch off large-scale disturbances in the State where the Lok Dal leader Devi Lal is waiting for an opportunity to stage a come-back.

BEHIND all these calculations, looms the grim reality that the Congress-I leadership is not as confident of holding the party together in the face of challenges ahead. This is true not only in Haryana, but in other areas as well as could be seen in its handling of the Kamalapati Tripathi episode.

Kamalapati Tripathi has long been regarded as an old-world character, left like a neglected ancient monument in the kingdom of Congress. Few took his political views seriously even before senility overtook him though he occasionally was made use of by many a politician from Indira Gandhi downward. The reason for this is that he is the chieftain of the Brahmin battalion in the UP Congress deducing his descent from the priesthood of the holiest of Varanasi temples. To ditch him or to antagonise him might